

Qroo Spanish Crew

Conjugating Verbs in the Preterit Tense

Introduction

The preterit tense in Spanish is used to describe actions that are completed and occurred at a specific point in the past. This guide will explain how to conjugate regular verbs in the preterit tense, followed by irregular verbs grouped by similar patterns.

Regular Verbs

Regular verbs in the preterit tense follow distinct patterns based on their infinitive endings: **-AR**, **-ER**, and **-IR**. Here are the conjugation endings for each type:

Conjugation Endings for Regular Verbs

Subject Pronoun	-AR Ending	-ER Ending	-IR Ending
yo	-é	-í	-í
tú	-aste	-iste	-iste
él/ella/usted	-ó	-ió	-ió
nosotros/nosotras	-amos	-imos	-imos
vosotros/vosotras (Spain only)	-asteis	-isteis	-isteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	-aron	-ieron	-ieron

Examples of Regular Verbs

-AR Verbs

- **Hablar (to speak):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	hablé
tú	hablaste
él/ella/usted	habló
nosotros	hablamos
vosotros	hablasteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	hablaron

-ER Verbs

- **Comer (to eat):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	comí
tú	comiste
él/ella/usted	comió
nosotros	comimos
vosotros	comisteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	comieron

-IR Verbs

- **Vivir (to live):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
yo	viví
tú	viviste
él/ella/usted	vivió
nosotros	vivimos
vosotros	vivisteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	vivieron

Irregular Verbs

Unlike regular verbs, irregular verbs in the preterit tense do not follow standard patterns. Below, these verbs are grouped by their irregularities.

Irregular Stem Verbs

Many irregular verbs in the preterit have unique stems. The endings, however, remain consistent for all these verbs:

Subject Pronoun Ending

yo	-e
tú	-iste
él/ella/usted	-o
nosotros	-imos
vosotros	-isteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	-ieron

Common Irregular Stem Verbs

Infinitive Stem Example Conjugation (yo form)

tener	tuv-	tuve
estar	estuv-	estuve
poder	pud-	pude
saber	sup-	supe
venir	vin-	vine

Verbs Ending in -car, -gar, and -zar

These verbs have spelling changes in the **yo** form to maintain pronunciation:

- **-car:** The "c" changes to "qu" (e.g., buscar > yo busqué)
- **-gar:** The "g" changes to "gu" (e.g., pagar > yo pagué)
- **-zar:** The "z" changes to "c" (e.g., comenzar > yo comencé)

Irregular Verbs: Ser and Ir

The verbs **ser** and **ir** share the same conjugation in the preterit:

Subject Pronoun Conjugation

yo	fui
tú	fuiste
él/ella/usted	fue
nosotros	fuimos
vosotros	fuisteis
ellos/ellas/ustedes	fueron

Stem-Changing -IR Verbs

Stem-changing **-IR** verbs undergo a vowel change in the third person (singular and plural):

- **dormir (to sleep):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
él/ella/usted	durmió
ellos/ellas/ustedes	durmieron

- **pedir (to ask for):**

Subject Pronoun	Conjugation
él/ella/usted	pidió
ellos/ellas/ustedes	pidieron

Summary

This guide covers the formation of the preterit tense for both regular and irregular verbs. Regular verbs follow predictable patterns, while irregular verbs often require memorization. With practice, mastering the preterit tense will become much easier and allow you to express past events effectively.